

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Real Estate English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For real estate agents, brokers, transaction coordinators, property managers, leasing teams, and commercial real estate staff.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

Absorption rate

Pace at which available inventory is sold or leased in a market segment.

Agency disclosure

Required explanation or document identifying the professional's role and who is represented.

Appraisal

Independent opinion of value often required by a lender.

Appraisal gap

Difference between contract price and appraised value that can create financing or negotiation issues.

Backup offer

Offer accepted or held in position if the primary contract fails, depending on local practice.

Blockbusting

Inducing sales by suggesting protected-class changes will affect property values or neighborhood conditions.

Buyer representation agreement

Agreement defining buyer services, term, compensation, exclusivity, and other obligations.

CAM

Common area maintenance charges in some commercial leases.

Cap rate

Capitalization rate; NOI divided by property value or price, used as a valuation shorthand.

Clear to close

Lender status indicating conditions are substantially satisfied for closing.

Client

A person represented by the real estate professional under an agency or representation relationship.

Closing Disclosure

Mortgage disclosure showing final or near-final loan terms, costs, and cash to close.

CMA

Comparative market analysis using comparable properties and market data to support pricing.

Comp

Comparable property used to estimate likely market value.

Concession

Seller or landlord contribution to buyer or tenant costs, repairs, or other terms.

Contingency

Contract condition that must be satisfied or waived for the transaction to continue.

Customer

A person receiving limited services or information but not represented as a client, depending on state law.

Designated agency

Same brokerage but different designated agents represent different clients, where permitted.

DOM

Days on market; how long a property has been publicly listed under local rules.

Dual agency

Representation of both buyer and seller in the same transaction where allowed and properly disclosed.

Earnest money

Deposit showing buyer seriousness, handled according to contract and escrow rules.

Escalation clause

Offer term that may increase price under specified competing-offer conditions.

Escrow

Neutral holding and coordination of funds, documents, or closing conditions, depending on state practice.

Fiduciary duty

Duties such as loyalty, confidentiality, disclosure, obedience, reasonable care, and accounting, depending on law and role.

Inspection period

Time allowed for property inspection and related negotiations.

Lead-based paint disclosure

Federal disclosure requirements for many pre-1978 residential properties.

Lease term

Length and conditions of a lease agreement.

Lien

Legal claim against property that may need resolution before or during closing.

List price

Price at which the property is offered to the market.

Listing agreement

Contract between seller and brokerage defining listing services, term, price, compensation, and conditions.

Loan Estimate

Mortgage disclosure showing estimated loan terms, payments, closing costs, and cash to close.

Material fact

Fact that could affect a party's decision or property value, subject to applicable law.

NNN

Triple net lease structure where tenant may pay taxes, insurance, and maintenance in addition to base rent.

NOI

Net operating income; property income after operating expenses but before debt service and some other items.

Pre-approval

Lender review indicating likely borrowing capacity, subject to underwriting and property review.

Proof of funds

Documentation showing funds available for cash purchase or down payment.

Proration

Allocation of taxes, HOA dues, rent, or other costs between parties by date.

Protected class

A legally protected characteristic under federal, state, or local fair housing laws.

Reasonable accommodation

Change in rules or services that may be needed for a person with a disability.

Redlining

Denying or limiting housing-related services in areas based on protected characteristics or similar unlawful criteria.

Rent roll

Schedule of rents, tenants, lease dates, and payment status for a property.

RESPA Section 8

Federal restrictions on kickbacks, unearned fees, and referral payments in covered settlement services.

Sale price

Final contract or closed price, depending on context.

Screening criteria

Objective rental applicant criteria such as income, credit, rental history, and occupancy rules.

Security deposit

Funds held to cover certain tenant obligations, subject to state and local rules.

Steering

Directing people toward or away from housing based on protected-class characteristics.

Title search

Review of public records to confirm ownership and identify liens, easements, or other issues.

Underwriting

Lender review of borrower, property, income, assets, credit, and loan risk.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Agency, Representation, Compensation, and Trust

A prospective buyer asks whether an agent represents both sides. The relationship has not yet been established or documented.

Before we discuss a property, let's clarify who would represent whom and review the required disclosures and agreements. The available arrangements depend on the applicable rules and the parties' agreement.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

02 | Client Intake, Needs Analysis, and Property Search

A buyer asks for a "good neighborhood" and "a short commute." They have not specified transport, budget, or property needs.

What commute time and transport options would work for you? Let's also list your budget and property requirements so we can use clear, relevant criteria for the search.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

03 | Listings, Property Descriptions, Pricing, and Market Data

A pricing presentation uses three recent sales, but one property is much larger and another required major repairs.

These sales provide context, but they are not identical to the property. I'll explain the differences in size and condition and how they limit the comparison instead of presenting one certain sale price.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

04 | Showings, Open Houses, Fair Housing, and Advertising

A listing draft uses vague claims about the "ideal type of family." The team needs a description focused on the property.

Please describe the rooms, features, and location facts instead. We can make the listing informative by stating what the property offers and sending the wording through our advertising review.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

05 | Offers, Counteroffers, Negotiation, and Contingencies

A proposed offer requests completion in 30 days. The buyer's financing timeline is still provisional.

The buyer prefers 30 days, but the financing timeline is not confirmed. Could we discuss the proposed timing and any relevant contingencies with the appropriate parties before making a firm commitment?

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

06 | Inspections, Repairs, Disclosures, and Due Diligence

An inspection report identifies an issue and recommends specialist evaluation. A buyer asks the agent to diagnose it.

The report identifies a concern but does not establish its full cause or repair cost. We can help arrange the recommended specialist review so you have better information for your decision.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

07 | Financing, Appraisal, Title, Escrow, and Closing

A transaction checklist shows the appraisal received but title questions still open. A client asks whether everything is ready to close.

The appraisal has been received. Title questions remain open, so I cannot say that every closing item is complete. I'll confirm the outstanding items and the next update with the responsible professionals.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

08 | Leasing, Property Management, Commercial Basics, Ethics, and Crisis Scenarios

A tenant has reported a leak twice and received no update. The property team has logged the issue but has no confirmed appointment.

I'm sorry you have had to follow up. The issue is logged, but I do not yet have a confirmed appointment. I'll contact the responsible team and update you today, even if the timing is still pending.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.